DSEH004 · PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT

IV

UNIT IV READER

Culture and Talent

Mentoring, learning, high performance work systems, recognition and the culture that makes it last

Weeks 10 to 12 | Exam preparation | 6 readings explained

R K Singh, Senior Professor · Department of Commerce, Delhi School of Economics, University of Delhi

M.Com. PGCF 2025 · Academic Year 2026 to 27 · Exam preparation edition

About this reader

HOW TO USE IT

This reader is a companion to the set readings, not a replacement for them. For each reading it explains the argument in plain language, lists the ideas you must hold, shows how to apply them, flags common confusions, and gives questions to think with as you prepare for the end term examination. Read the original first, then use this reader to check your understanding. Folder names refer to the course Readings folder.

Unit IV asks what makes a performance and engagement system last. Its readings cover how people develop (mentoring and learning on the job), how practices combine into systems (high performance work systems), how organizations show people they are valued (recognition), and the culture that holds it all together (psychological safety).

The unit also closes the course. Week 12 Lecture 3 brings Units I to IV together, and its set reading is a review of the eight core readings. Use the final section of this reader to plan that review.

READING MAP

Week	Set readings	Folder	Exam edition lectures
10	Eby et al. (2008); Jennings (2013); Pfeffer (1998) Ch 2	Unit 4 / Unit 4:Core (Jennings and Pfeffer not yet filed)	L1 to L3
11	Brun and Dugas (2008); Edmondson (1999)	Unit 4 / Unit 4:Core	L1, L2
12	Review of the eight core readings (L3 only)	All folders	L3

The readings, one by one

Week 10 Core

Eby, L. T., Allen, T. D., Evans, S. C., Ng, T., & DuBois, D. L. (2008). Does mentoring matter? A multidisciplinary meta analysis comparing mentored and non mentored individuals. *Journal of Vocational Behavior, 72*(2), 254–267.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Eby and colleagues meta analyzed studies comparing mentored and non mentored people across youth, academic and workplace mentoring. Mentoring was associated with favorable behavioral, attitudinal, health related, relational, motivational and career outcomes, but most of the effects were small. The authors conclude that mentoring helps, but less than its popularity suggests, and that the quality of the relationship matters.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Mentoring is associated with a wide range of better outcomes.
- Most effect sizes are small.
- The quality of the relationship is a likely active ingredient.

APPLY IT

When designing a program, aim for relationship quality, not the number of pairs. Ragins, Cotton and Miller (2000) found satisfaction with the relationship mattered more than whether it was formal or informal.

EASY TO CONFUSE

Small average effects do not mean mentoring does not work. They mean its effect varies, so design choices matter.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Why might informal mentoring outperform assigned mentoring?
- How would you measure whether a mentoring program changed careers, not just satisfaction?

Week 10 Practitioner

Jennings, C. (2013). *70:20:10 framework explained* [Practitioner monograph]. (Listed in the Lesson Plan; year not independently confirmed.)

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

The 70:20:10 framework holds that most learning at work comes from experience on the job, a smaller share from other people, and the least from formal training. Practitioners such as Jennings present it as a reminder that development should be built into work, not confined to courses, and stress that the numbers are not a fixed ratio.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Most workplace learning happens through work itself.
- Learning from others is a major source.
- The ratio is a heuristic, not a measured law.

APPLY IT

Use 70:20:10 to argue for designing development into jobs and relationships. Then cite Clardy (2018): the ratio itself has not been established by research.

EASY TO CONFUSE

Do not quote 70:20:10 as a research finding. Its origin is interviews with successful executives (McCall, Lombardo and Morrison, 1988). The year of the Jennings piece listed in the Lesson Plan could not be independently confirmed.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- If the ratio is not a law, what is it still useful for?

Week 10 Core

Pfeffer, J. (1998). *The human equation: Building profits by putting people first*. Harvard Business School Press. Chapter 2.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Pfeffer argues that organizations make profits by putting people first, and that a set of practices separates successful organizations from others: employment security, selective hiring, self managed teams and decentralization, high pay contingent on performance, extensive training, reduced status differences, and sharing information. The practices work together as a system, and adopting one or two in isolation brings little.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- People centered practices are a source of competitive advantage.
- Seven practices, each with its own mechanism.
- The practices work as a system, not one at a time.

APPLY IT

Use the ability, motivation and opportunity bundles (Jiang et al., 2012) to group the practices, then raise the causality question from Wright et al. (2005).

EASY TO CONFUSE

Pfeffer makes a strong case, but the evidence is mostly correlational. Profitable firms may adopt these practices because they can afford them.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Which two practices would most change an Indian manufacturing firm within a year?
- Why might employment security be the hardest practice to adopt?

Week 11 Core

Brun, J. P., & Dugas, N. (2008). An analysis of employee recognition: Perspectives on human resources practices. *International Journal of Human Resource Management, 19*(4), 716–730.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Brun and Dugas ask what employee recognition really is. They analyze four conceptual approaches to recognition: ethical, humanistic and existential, work psychodynamic, and behavioral. They distinguish what recognition can be given for: the person, the way work is done, effort and dedication, and results. They argue that most organizations recognize results alone, and that recognition is a management practice as well as a human need.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Recognition can be understood through several theoretical approaches.
- Recognition can target the person, work practice, dedication or results.
- Most programs recognize only results.

APPLY IT

Design recognition that covers practice and dedication as well as results, so that people whose results depend on others are also seen.

EASY TO CONFUSE

Recognition is not just cheaper pay. Under self determination theory, recognition that informs competence supports motivation, while recognition used to control can undermine it (Deci, Koestner and Ryan, 1999).

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Why might "employee of the month" harm those not chosen?
- How could recognition be designed for a collectivist team?

Week 11 Core

Edmondson, A. C. (1999). Psychological safety and learning behavior in work teams. *Administrative Science Quarterly, 44*(2), 350–383.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Edmondson introduced team psychological safety: a shared belief that the team is safe for interpersonal risk taking. In a study of 51 work teams in a manufacturing company, psychological

safety was associated with learning behavior, while team efficacy was not once safety was controlled. Learning behavior mediated between psychological safety and team performance. Context support and coaching by team leaders helped shape these beliefs.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Psychological safety is a shared team belief about interpersonal risk.
- It predicts learning behavior, which links to performance.
- Leader coaching and support shape it.

APPLY IT

Use psychological safety to explain why a team hides errors. A system that punishes reported mistakes will see fewer reports, not fewer mistakes.

EASY TO CONFUSE

Psychological safety is not comfort or low standards. It works best combined with high accountability. It is also a team level belief, unlike Kahn's individual safety condition.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- How could a performance review process raise or lower psychological safety?
- How does Edmondson's construct differ from Kahn's safety condition?

Week 12 Review

Comprehensive review of the core readings for Lecture 3: Kahn (1990), Bakker and Demerouti (2017), Deci and Ryan (2008), Locke and Latham (2002), Buckingham and Goodall (2015), Pink (2009), Csikszentmihalyi (1990), Schaufeli and Bakker (2004).

HOW TO READ IT

Do not reread passively. For each core reading, write from memory its main claim, one strength, one weakness and one Indian example, then check against the Unit II and Unit I Readers. Then practise the comparisons the examination favors: Kahn against the Q12, Job Demands Resources against self determination theory, self determination theory against psychological capital, and OKRs against the balanced scorecard.

The course in one map

The four units form one argument. Use this map to connect concepts across units, which earns the integration marks in the examination.

Stage	Unit	Core question	Key readings
Diagnosis	Unit II	Why are people engaged or not?	Kahn; Bakker and Demerouti; Deci and Ryan
Design	Unit I	What system manages performance?	Locke and Latham; Doerr; Kaplan and Norton
Strategy	Unit III	How do we act on engagement at scale?	Saks; Costanza et al.; Cappelli
Culture	Unit IV	What makes it last?	Pfeffer; Brun and Dugas; Edmondson

KEY TERMS

Term	Meaning
Meta analysis	A statistical synthesis of many studies to estimate an average effect.
70:20:10	A heuristic that most learning happens through work, not a research finding.
High performance work system	A bundle of mutually reinforcing HR practices.
Recognition	Acknowledging a person, their work practice, their dedication or their results.
Psychological safety	A shared belief that the team is safe for interpersonal risk taking.

References

Brun, J. P., & Dugas, N. (2008). An analysis of employee recognition: Perspectives on human resources practices. *International Journal of Human Resource Management, 19*(4), 716–730. https://doi.org/10.1080/09585190801953723

Clardy, A. (2018). 70:20:10 and the dominance of informal learning: A fact in search of evidence. *Human Resource Development Review, 17*(2), 153–178. https://doi.org/10.1177/1534484318759399

Deci, E. L., Koestner, R., & Ryan, R. M. (1999). A meta analytic review of experiments examining the effects of extrinsic rewards on intrinsic motivation. *Psychological Bulletin, 125*(6), 627–668. https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.125.6.627

Eby, L. T., Allen, T. D., Evans, S. C., Ng, T., & DuBois, D. L. (2008). Does mentoring matter? A multidisciplinary meta analysis comparing mentored and non mentored individuals. *Journal of Vocational Behavior, 72*(2), 254–267. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jvb.2007.04.005

Edmondson, A. C. (1999). Psychological safety and learning behavior in work teams. *Administrative Science Quarterly, 44*(2), 350–383. https://doi.org/10.2307/2666999

Jennings, C. (2013). *70:20:10 framework explained* [Practitioner monograph]. (Listed in the Lesson Plan; year not independently confirmed.)

Jiang, K., Lepak, D. P., Hu, J., & Baer, J. C. (2012). How does human resource management influence organizational outcomes? A meta analytic investigation of mediating mechanisms. *Academy of Management Journal, 55*(6), 1264–1294. https://doi.org/10.5465/amj.2011.0088

McCall, M. W., Lombardo, M. M., & Morrison, A. M. (1988). *The lessons of experience: How successful executives develop on the job*. Lexington Books.

Pfeffer, J. (1998). *The human equation: Building profits by putting people first*. Harvard Business School Press.

Ragins, B. R., Cotton, J. L., & Miller, J. S. (2000). Marginal mentoring: The effects of type of mentor, quality of relationship, and program design on work and career attitudes. *Academy of Management Journal, 43*(6), 1177–1194. https://doi.org/10.2307/1556344

Wright, P. M., Gardner, T. M., Moynihan, L. M., & Allen, M. R. (2005). The relationship between HR practices and firm performance: Examining causal order. *Personnel Psychology, 58*(2), 409–446. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1744-6570.2005.00487.x

All references were checked against Crossref, publisher or library records, except that the year of Jennings (2013) could not be independently confirmed; it is listed as given in the Lesson Plan.